

something useful. (I know one friend who prided herself on not buying new clothes but was astonished one month to see that she spent almost 25% of her take-home pay on going out to eat). And if you and your partner fight about money, a computer budgeting program can be especially helpful because it offers an objective way to see where the money is actually going.

- **Use your checkbook.** If you still use checks, your checkbook can actually be a handy organizing tool. Every time you write a check, note the merchant, the amount, and the date in the ledger or save the carbon copy. Write down or save ATM receipts in the same place. This can be a good reminder of how much is going to be taken from your account when the check is cashed.

There are also some useful websites and publications that provide insights into saving and help with budgeting. Try *Money* (www.money.com), *Kiplinger's* (www.kiplinger.com), and *SmartMoney* (www.smartmoney.com).

↓ FINANCIAL CRAMMING

- **To calculate how much you need to save each month to reach specific financial goals, look at Figure 2–1 on chapter 1. Although it's based on several assumptions about inflation, your tax bracket, and the rate you'll be able to earn on investments, it will still give you a rough idea of how much money you'll need to set aside.**
- **Keep a spending diary for one month. By forcing yourself to write down everything you spend money on, you'll get a better sense of why your cash seems to disappear.**
- **Consider these guidelines when evaluating your financial fitness: Spend no more than 30% of your monthly take-home pay on housing and dedicate at least 10% of your**